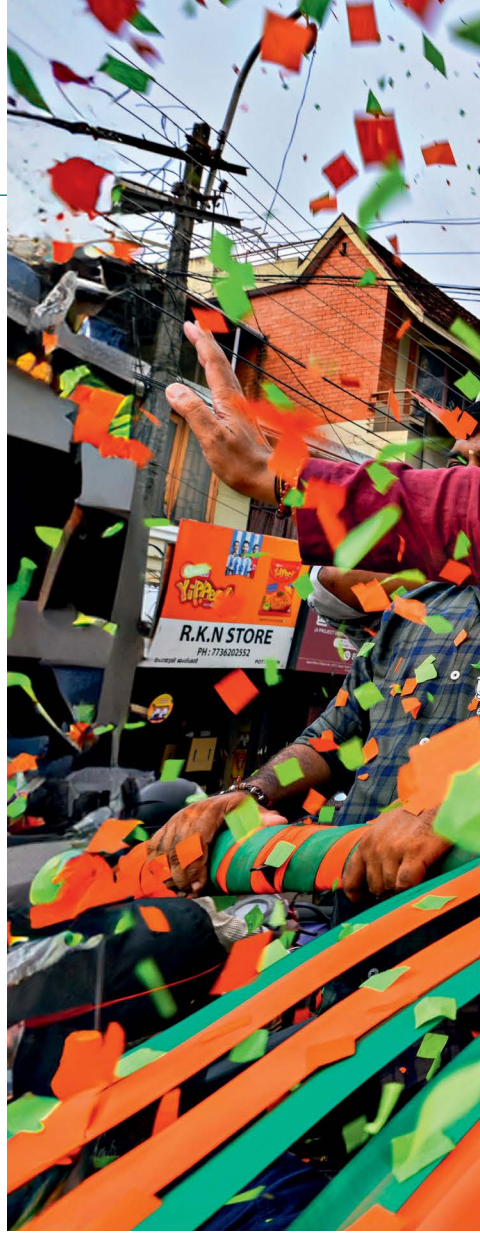


ing for the media's cameras, performing before the public. The BJP-ruled Centre had made three specific promises for Kerala; none has been fulfilled, including the setting up of an AIIMS."

High-stakes Battle

Both Tharoor and Chandrasekhar are acutely aware of just how high the stakes are in the battle over Thiruvananthapuram. The BJP has never won a Lok Sabha seat in Kerala, with the two leading alliances of the state—the United Democratic Front (UDF) led by the Congress and the Left Democratic Front (LDF) headed by the Communist Party India (Marxist) or CPI(M)—usually sharing the 20 seats of the state between them. Over the years, the pendulum has largely swung between these two fronts, with the UDF coming out on top in 2019, winning 19 out of the 20 seats. But Tharoor says the fight for his seat has got tougher, with the BJP emerging as the clear alternative, unlike in most other constituencies in the state. Though he won the 2019 election with a margin of 99,989 votes, securing 41.1 per cent of the vote share, the BJP candidate K. Rajashekaran emerged as the runner-up with 31.3 per cent, pushing the Communist Party of India's (CPI) C. Divakaran to third place. This time too, Tharoor expects Chandrasekhar to be his prime opponent, though the CPI has put up its state secretary, 79-year-old Pannyan Raveendran as its candidate. There lies a tale behind Raveendran's distinctively long hair. He started growing it to protest police harassment of young rebels with hippie hairdos during the Emergency, and hasn't cut it ever since. Though both the UDF and the LDF are part of the I.N.D.I.A. bloc, they do not have a seat-sharing arrangement in the state, giving the BJP some advantage.

If Chandrasekhar pulls off an upset, he would earn the rare distinction of being the BJP's first ever Lok Sabha MP from the state. For the BJP, it would mean admittance at last into a bastion that it has worked hard to breach for over three decades without success. For the Congress, Tharoor's constituency is the most vulnerable, as the percentage of Hindus in Thiruvananthapuram is a high 64 per cent, with Christians constituting 19.1 per cent and Muslims 13.7 per cent of the population. More pertinently, some 24 per cent are Nairs, who have a history of being anti-left and are thought to have turned saffronward of late. The 'soft Hindu' mocktail that Tharoor had brewed successfully is being challenged by Chandrasekhar, whose background appeals to the digital generation enamoured by his status as minister for information technology and not captive to card-holding politics. Despite the sylvan high ranges on its west and the fishing economy that defines its littoral, there's the broad fact of Thiruvananthapuram being a 72 per cent urban seat with younger voters dreaming of netting infotech jobs rather than trawling for fish.

CHANDRASEKHAR HAS NEVER LIVED IN KERALA, BUT IT IS NOT SEEN AS A DISADVANTAGE, AS THAROOR, TOO, HAD BEEN PARACHUTED IN

Contrasting Personalities

Others see it as the battle between two contrasting personalities—one a legatee of Nehruvian chic, who represents sheer Anglophone sophistry and smooth global citizenship, often the highest two aspirations of modern-day Kerala. The other is a political persona who is an extension of the same post-Nineties vibe that his resume resonates with. But more than that, as a paragon of desirable socio-economic traits, he ticks many of the boxes that Tharoor does in contemporary Kerala—with extra digital neon lighting. If Tharoor finds the sands a touch mobile under his feet, it's also because the overwhelmingly Latin Catholic fishing communities—who weigh in at about 10-11 per cent—are upset with him for not backing their protests against the Adani port at Vizhinjam. As for the Muslims, roughly the same demographic size, Tharoor's nuanced balancing on the Gaza conflict didn't cut ice with them—especially when he labelled Hamas as a 'terror group' at a